



AN AGENT WITH the Department of Homeland Security on patrol in snowy St. Paul, Minn., on Saturday. ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

ICE has lost the public trust, maybe for good

Uncertainty over who’s being targeted prompts residents to mobilize, regardless.

By BRITTNY MEJIA AND RUBEN VIVES

The ICE officers descended on Compton, targeting immigrants convicted of theft, child abuse and selling drugs.

There were no protesters. No whistles alerting targets to the officers’ presence. No face masks. In some cases, residents opened their doors to let the officers inside their homes. One man thanked them for not arresting him in front of his children.

The Los Angeles-area operation ended with 162 arrests, including a Mexican national convicted of rape and a Salvadoran national convicted of voluntary manslaughter. Immigration and Customs Enforcement said almost 90% of the people arrested had criminal convictions.

It was June 2018, more than a year into Donald Trump’s first term as presi-

dent. More than seven years later, carrying out the same operation in L.A. or other U.S. cities feels almost impossible without drawing angry crowds and requiring multiple officers, at times across federal agencies, to detain a single target.

In the years since Trump’s first term, ICE and the government’s immigration enforcement apparatus expanded raids well beyond those against known criminals or suspected ones. Increasingly, immigrants with no criminal records and even legal residents and U.S. citizens found themselves stopped and sometimes arrested.

The uncertainty over who is being targeted has fueled a growing pattern of community protests and rapid response mobilizations, even when officials say they are targeting convicted felons, reflecting a widening gap between how enforcement is described and how it is experienced. That gap has become most visible on the ground.

In recent months, sightings of ICE or other federal agents have drawn crowds of protesters, legal observers [See Trust, A6]

New ‘space race’ hits turbulence

The rolling grasslands and rocky beaches of Vandenberg Space Force Base, home to more than a dozen at-risk species, easily could pass for a peaceful nature preserve — but that’s an illusion.

The nearly 100,000-acre base in Santa Barbara County was a testing ground in the 1960s for early-generation ballistic missiles, and today it’s a launch site for satellites, classified missions and other payloads key to a new type of war: one fought far above the Earth.

This new era has been marked by a sharp jump in flights from the military facility that started in 2021 when SpaceX began sending into orbit Starlink internet satellites the military considers critical for national

Vandenberg base is ready to soar, but for some it’s all a big noise

By Laurence Darmiento



VANDENBERG Space Force Base aims to expand its number of launches and attract aerospace companies. ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

security.

Now Vandenberg is aiming higher with its Spaceport of the Future initiative. The agency is making plans for a nearly \$900-million makeover of the aging base with roads, buildings, launchpads and other facilities to handle an anticipated surge in launches.

Seventy-one rockets blasted off last year, most of them by SpaceX. One hundred or more could take off this year, possibly making it the busiest space port in the world.

“We’re in the beginnings of the second space race. That’s what you’re seeing,” said U.S. Space Force Col. James Horne III, base commander, whose office is decorated with nearly two [See Space Force, A11]

Mexican leader’s finesse won over Trump

Sheinbaum has fended off tariffs and drones, but she’s also given in on security issues.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND PATRICK J. McDONNELL

MEXICO CITY — He has called Colombian President Gustavo Petro “a sick man” and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky a “dictator.” He once slammed French President Emmanuel Macron as “publicity-seeking,” and former Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau as “dishonest and weak.”

President Trump is known for hurling scathing insults at world leaders.

Then there’s Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum. The U.S. president has described her, at turns, as “fantastic,” “terrific” and “elegant.”

In a social media post Thursday, he offered his most glowing compliments yet, extolling Sheinbaum as “wonderful and highly intelligent” and saying Mexicans “should be very happy” to have her as their leader.

Trump’s emphatic praise for Sheinbaum is surprising, given their marked differences in temperament and politics.

Sheinbaum, a leftist known for her patience and pragmatism, labeled Israel’s U.S.-backed war in Gaza a “genocide” and condemned the recent U.S. capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro.

She disagrees with Trump on three of his firmly [See Sheinbaum, A4]

A remote border fence may sever lifeline for rare sheep

Razor wire cuts off bighorn from water source

By Lila Seidman

JACUMBA WILDERNESS, Calif. — On a dirt road in Imperial County leading toward the Mexico border, the tracks of rare wild sheep press into dusty tire tracks, amid jumbled boulders and spindly ocotillo. The white trucks and SUVs of the U.S. Border Patrol appear like ghosts in the desert.

Here, in the Jacumba Wilderness, people are halted at the border by federal agents, but Peninsular bighorn sheep have long migrated back and forth. The ewes give birth on the U.S. side in the winter and spring, then cross into Mexico to seek water in the punishing summer.

But some say they’ll be blocked this year. Recently, something new appeared on the landscape, alarming wildlife advocates like Christina Aiello. It glitters from

a distance: Where the 30-foot steel border fence ends, great spirals of razor wire extend up craggy mountain slopes on each side.

U.S. Customs and Border Protection had announced plans to finish sealing off all 140 miles of the California-Mexico border, including in this remote wilderness.

“It will light a fire under us,” said Aiello, of the Wildlands Network, a conservation nonprofit.

Advocates like Aiello are racing to secure measures to avoid catastrophe before the frontier is closed.

They want to install water sources for sheep stranded on the U.S. side. Without it, “you will see piles of dead sheep,” said Aiello, who is a wildlife biologist.

[See Bighorn, A10]



SHEEP lamb in the U.S., then cross into Mexico for water in the summer. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

A partisan divide on DOJ credibility

Democrats say recent pattern of words and action has created a public crisis.

By KEVIN RECTOR, SEEMA MEHTA AND ANA CEBALLOS

Leading Democrats have rolled out a new and unvarnished message — that the U.S. Department of Justice cannot be trusted.

“Let’s be really clear: We can’t trust anything the DOJ does. The DOJ is corrupt. They’re corrupt on every major issue in front of this country,” Rep. Robert Garcia (D-Long Beach), ranking member on the House Oversight Committee, said Friday at a news conference in his district.

“We cannot trust the Department of Justice. They

ICE account of injury disputed

Minnesota nurses reject claim that a man ran headfirst into wall, fracturing skull. NATION, A5

are an illegitimate organization right now under the leadership of [Atty. Gen.] Pam Bondi and the direction of Donald Trump,” House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-N.Y.) said during his own news conference in Washington, D.C.

The remarks — which hold profound implications in a two-party democracy meant to be protected and served by a nonpartisan justice system, and which a White House spokesperson called “shameful” — followed a week of equally stunning actions by the Justice [See Justice, A7]

With AI, stop typing and just talk instead

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

Gavin McNamara has abandoned his keyboard and spends all day talking rather than typing.

He speaks for hours with his computer and phone, sending emails, writing presentations, posting on LinkedIn and even coding through conversations using an AI dictation app from San Francisco startup, Wispr Flow.

The AI punctuates, formats and adapts his rambling into coherent copy. McNamara averages 125 words per minute, which is twice the average typing speed.

“At this point, anything that could be done by typing,

I do by speaking,” said the 32-year-old, founder of software agency Why Not Us. “I just talk.”

Across 77 apps, he has dictated nearly 300,000 words in the past five months — that’s equivalent to writing three novels.

California’s tech titans and startups are at the forefront of a movement to use AI and the large language models they are based on to push people to interact with technology using their voices rather than their fingers.

“AI and LLMs have changed the dynamic,” said CJ Pais, the San Diego-based creator of free voice-to-text dictation app Handy. [See Dictation, A13]

Testing limits of 1st Amendment

Don Lemon’s arrest signals escalation by Trump against media. BUSINESS, A12

LA28 chairman is in Epstein files

Casey Wasserman exchanged emails with Ghislaine Maxwell. CALIFORNIA, B1

Comfort food on several levels

Two chefs who lost homes in Altadena reopen distinct restaurants. WEEKEND, L4

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Weather

Partly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 81/53. B3

